



PROGRESS REPORT

North Africa: progress report, September 2025 – September 2026

Edition of 2026-09-02-2 · 10 systems and instruments tracked

Compiled 2026-09-02 by Claude Opus from the documents in the Corpus repository. Sections run from the region's institutions outwards to what funds them. Each opens with a movement ledger comparing the position at the start and end of the period, which runs to the date of issue rather than to the last month's close.

SUMMARY OF THE PERIOD · INSTITUTIONS AND MANDATES · INSTRUMENTS AND HARMONISATION ·
SHARED SYSTEMS AND INFRASTRUCTURE

Of 10 bodies, instruments and systems on this place's ledger, 9 changed position between 2025-09-01 and 2026-09-02, 0 did not, 1 carry no stated baseline, and 0 are **Not held** at both ends.

Shape check, run before the comparison: 8 sources for this place in the window — 3 in the earlier half (2025-12 to 2026-02), 5 in the later (2026-07 to 2026-08). The two halves are comparable, so the comparison is made over the whole window.

Movement values. *Advanced* — a system entered service, a stage was completed or an instrument was made. *Stalled* — a stated target passed without delivery. *Regressed* — an instrument was withdrawn or neutralised, or a measured position worsened. *Closed* — the programme ended. *No change* — the position at both ends is the same. *Baseline not held* — the base carries no position at the start of the period, so no movement can be stated. A value may carry a qualifying clause after a comma, as in *Advanced, slipped*.

Summary of the period

North Africa's ledger opens thin and moves through the Arab League rather than through the AU's continental instruments: two separate AI-ethics charters, a newly staffed AI governance committee, and a conference of civil-status directors, none of them AU-organised. The one running infrastructure programme on the ledger — the France–Tunisia leg of the Medusa submarine cable — reached service during the period, while Ookla's year-one measurement of the region's 5G launches found the aggregate mobile experience worse than before them in three of four markets. PAPSS's North Africa footprint reached four of the region's five states with Algeria's accession, and a stablecoin-based neobank entered the base as the one private-sector system tracked here.

Institutions and mandates

Regional collaboration

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-09-01	AT 2026-09-02	MOVEMENT
Arab conference of nationality and civil-status directors (recommendations)	Did not exist	Recommended member states expand reliance on digital identity, strengthen legal frameworks protecting personal data in civil-status registers, and share defences against cyber threats aimed at those registers; a model data-protection framework for civil-status registers is to be circulated, and Iraq's proposal for a unified Arab identity was referred to member states for study	ADVANCED
Arab ICT Ministers Council AI working groups (AICTM Executive Bureau)	Did not exist	Six working groups chartered under the Arab League's AI governance/digital committee at the 58th AICTM Executive Bureau session; Egypt chairs AI Governance and Quantum Computing, Libya chairs AI Data and Digital Infrastructure, Tunisia chairs AI Innovation — the Governance group's remit includes activating the 2025 Arab Charter for AI Ethics; no framework text, timetable or output yet published from any of the six groups	ADVANCED

Both rows on this section are new this year and both are Arab League tracks rather than AU or REC ones. The AI committee now has its six working groups staffed, three of them chaired by African states, with the Governance group tasked to activate the Arab Charter for AI Ethics — but no framework text or output from any group. The civil-status directors' conference produced recommendations on digital identity and register data protection, with no adoption route yet named.

Instruments and harmonisation

Standards

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-09-01	AT 2026-09-02	MOVEMENT
ALECSO Charter on Artificial Intelligence Ethics	Did not exist	Scoped to education, culture and scientific research; asks member states to amend domestic law to implement it and names technological sovereignty among its principles — a second, distinct Arab AI-ethics instrument from the Arab Charter for AI Ethics above	ADVANCED
Arab Charter for AI Ethics	Did not exist	Non-binding instrument carrying six pillars and about forty principles, including resisting "digital cultural westernisation" (مقاومة التغريب الرقمي), explicitly framed as guidance rather than a substitute for binding regulation	ADVANCED

Two Arab-League AI-ethics instruments sit on the ledger, adopted within weeks of each other in mid-2025 and routinely conflated with one another: the Arab Charter for AI Ethics is a general, non-binding six-pillar instrument covering forty principles, while the ALECSO charter is scoped narrowly to education, culture and scientific research and asks member states to amend domestic law. Neither carries an enforcement mechanism, and the AI governance committee's own working group tasked with "activating" the former has a chair but no published output as at this report.

Shared systems and infrastructure

Connectivity

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-09-01	AT 2026-09-02	MOVEMENT
Medusa submarine cable system — ViaTunisia (Bizerte–Marseille) segment	Under construction; EU CEF Digital co-financing of €9.6m against a €32m total project budget (the European Commission's own project record, correcting the €10m/~30% figure trade press had carried), project start 1 March 2023	Bizerte–Marseille segment operational, landing at Bizerte and connecting into Orange's Marseille interconnection hub; part of the wider 8,760km Medusa system, which the landing partner puts at 17 landing points across the northern and southern Mediterranean	ADVANCED
North Africa post-5G mobile network experience (Ookla)	Pre-5G-launch mobile network experience baseline (each market's own prior measurement)	Combined 4G+5G median ended below the pre-launch baseline in Egypt, Morocco and Tunisia a year after their 5G launches, with 4G itself down 28% in Morocco and Tunisia; Algeria — whose own 5G licences were only awarded in December 2025 — alone improved	REGRESSED, MIXED
Algerian 5G rollout	Not held	Launched on USD 492 million of licences awarded to the three mobile operators (2025-12)	BASELINE NOT HELD

Digital Payments and Fintech

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-09-01	AT 2026-09-02	MOVEMENT
Arab Payment Systems Commission (29th ordinary meeting)	Did not exist	Regulators set an agenda covering use of biometric data to limit payment fraud, security of the payments digital space and AI in payment-verification services, alongside instant payments and interoperability; no instrument, target date or funding figure is stated	ADVANCED
PAPSS membership in North Africa	Tunisia, Egypt and Morocco members	Tunisia, Egypt, Morocco and Algeria all members — four of North Africa's five states — within a continental network the operator puts at 18 countries, 150+ commercial banks and 14 switches	ADVANCED
VaulFi stablecoin-powered neobank	Did not exist	Algerian- and Egyptian-founded startup building a stablecoin-based neobank offering euro-denominated digital accounts across North Africa with cross-border settlement in minutes rather than days; live user accounts at the time of report, with stablecoin-powered cards stated to launch within weeks	ADVANCED

The one physical infrastructure project on the ledger reached service: the Bizerte–Marseille leg of the Medusa submarine cable, EU co-financed at €9.6m of a €32m budget, went operational in June, landing at Bizerte and joining the wider 17-point Medusa system. Against that single advance, the region's own 5G rollouts measure worse a year on: Ookla's retrospective found the aggregate mobile experience below its pre-launch baseline in three of the four markets that had launched by mid-2025, Algeria's later rollout the exception. Payments infrastructure moved on two fronts — the Arab Payment Systems Commission opened a fraud- and AI-in-verification agenda with nothing yet adopted, PAPSS's regional footprint reached four of five states, and a stablecoin-based neobank entered the base as the period's one private-sector system.

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